pertinent to Ghur. Citing the plentiful natural resources and mines of the region, as well as its well-known commodity of slaves, this author proposed that Ghur must have been linked with transregional commercial networks despite the absence of such references in the historical texts.[13] After all, Ghur's oft-cited mountainous landscape surely presented more difficulty for outsiders seeking access *into* the region, than for those long familiar with the terrain as they transported their goods *out*.

Thereafter in the twelfth century, the macroscopic perspectives of universal histories such as Ya'qut's (AH 575–626/1179–1229 CE) *Mu'jam al-buldan* and Ibn al-Athir's (d. AH 630/1233 CE) often cited *al-Kamil fi al-Tarikh* both mentioned Ghur and its inhabitants only infrequently. Even though they were by now more properly the ruling Shansabanis – identified thus by writers such as Nizami 'Aruzi, and Juzjani (see below) – they nevertheless continued to play minor roles in the eyes of the universal historians. As was the case in texts of various genres from the previous centuries, the Shansabanis made appearances principally when they intersected with the larger imperial formations of the Saljuqs and the Khwarazm-shahs. The expanded historical gazes and *raisons d'être* of these universal histories, then, seemed to alienate further this corner of the eastern Persianate lands and its inhabitants from the flow of the larger Islamic world.[14]

But at the same time, by the mid-twelfth century and the Shansabanis' initial ascendancy as a regional politico-military presence, the influx of unknown or unfamiliar power-seekers – warlords becoming warrior kings, to adapt terms used by M. A. Asif and A. Anooshahr[15] – and indeed their resounding successes within the Persianate world, were all undeniable and even well-known phenomena. So much so, that the invention of royal genealogies for newcomers was an integral labor performed by the scholarly *literati* whom these new courts patronized (cf. below). These invented genealogies created "a teleology of Islamic monarchies, [adhering to the] logic of historiographic expectations," which obviously occluded the rising groups' *historical* origins.[16]

Such a set of impetuses and intentions inhered in *Tabaqat-i nasiri* (completed before 1260), a universal history within the eponymous *tabaqa* genre of Persian historical writing. The work's author was the jurist and accomplished courtier Minhaj al-Din Siraj Juzjani (AH 589–658/1193–1260 CE) who, moreover, had been brought up within the Shansabani royal household at Firuzkuh. Despite *Tabaqat*'s ostensibly universal and trans-temporal purview, the disproportionately long sections (Ar.-Pers. *tabaqa*) on the Shansabanis revealed Juzjani's true focus. Following in the established tradition of royal genealogies, the author bestowed upon the Shansabanis the expected lineage springing from pre-Islamic mythology, whose principal repository was the *Shah-nama* and the literary production it engendered.[17] Admittedly, the requisite *genealogical* "origin myth" created for the Shansabanis was unusual, descending through the figure of Azhd